

TITLE

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Sequence 1

BLACK

SCOTT (V.O.)

Astronomers estimate about ten thousand stars in the universe for each grain of sand on earth. I think it's odd the two are compared. After all, people don't reach for sand.

They step on it.

INT. HOUSE PARTY - NIGHT

A typical college house party with drunk guys, tipsy girls and red solo cups. Trending music is blaring. People are split into smaller groups, two to six people.

One of those groups has DOM (19), who looks like he gets off to the others listening to him. He's the kind of guy who picks his interests based on how likely someone is to compliment or envy him.

We can't hear what they're talking about.

The music fades into the background. ELLA (19) and SCOTT (19), both unseen, are striking up a conversation like any hot couple who just met.

ELLA (O.S.)

No way. You're one-hundred percent kidding, Scott.

SCOTT (O.S.)

Not kidding.

ELLA (O.S.)

You got into USC for Film and TV. On a whim. Load of crap.

SCOTT (O.S.)

Maybe 'whim' is an exaggeration. But, all I did was have perfect grades and write a deeply personal essay for the application.

ELLA (O.S.)

Congrats on the new sixty-thousand dollar debt.

(MORE)

ELLA (O.S.) (cont'd)
Hope you'll enjoy fighting over
writing credits with everyone in
Hollywood.

SCOTT (O.S.)
What are you in debt for, Ella?

ELLA (O.S.)
Journalism.

SCOTT (O.S.)
Really? Didn't know USC had a good
program for that.

ELLA (O.S.)
Actually, I was shooting for music.
I'm in a band.

SCOTT (O.S.)
You are?

ELLA (O.S.)
Guitar and lead vocals. People come
here for connections, so I hope I
meet someone who can hook me up with
a record label exec.

SCOTT (O.S.)
And journalism, because...?

ELLA (O.S.)
It's fun to me.

SCOTT (O.S.)
I have never heard anyone say
journalism is fun.

ELLA (O.S.)
Do you know many journalists?

SCOTT (O.S.)
No, but I'd get it if you said
chasing that record deal's fun. Like
fighting over writing credit is fun.

ELLA (O.S.)
You think so?

SCOTT (O.S.)
Totally. People used to laugh at me
in school when I told them I wanted
to study film. But I pushed.
Persevered. I entered the Nicholl
last year.

ELLA (O.S.)
Oh, yeah? How'd that go?

SCOTT (O.S.)
Got a response back that essentially told me I sucked. Like they wanted me to never try again. But now I'm here.

ELLA (O.S.)
They sound harsh.

SCOTT (O.S.)
It's the academy. To be expected. But guess who ended up winning? A nepo baby. Same age as me, but daddy is a producer. Doesn't matter to me, I'll make it in the end.

ELLA (O.S.)
Glad you sound motivated, because there are only more nepo babies down the line now. They're probably already here.

SCOTT (O.S.)
Alright, then. Miss Journalist. Detective.

ELLA (O.S.)
Oh?

SCOTT (O.S.)
Find me someone like that in this room. Just so I know who to watch out for.

Switch over to show the two sweethearts. Scott looks like an unassuming guy with a conventionally attractive face. Ella looks like the pretty girl that gets everything for free.

Ella is laughing a bit too hard at what Scott just said, she's got intentions.

Scott doesn't hide his attraction, either.

ELLA
(nodding towards Dom)
Like him.

SCOTT
Who? The jack-ass who looks like he's been talking about himself the the past ten minutes?
(MORE)

SCOTT (cont'd)
Yeah, I think I can make it against him. Who is he, anyway?

ELLA
That's the thing. I met you just now, at this party, but I already know him. He's at just about every USC event. His name's Dom.

SCOTT
Every year has that uber-popular guy.

ELLA
That, and he's a trust fund baby. So he can afford partying this much.

SCOTT
Sorry, but this one doesn't count. You already new who he was. Doesn't show your detective skills.

ELLA
I'm surprised you don't know him. He's also in Film and Television.

SCOTT
I met like four people so far.

ELLA
Still think you'd make it against him?

SCOTT
I get what you mean. I should consider myself lucky to have gotten into the program at all. But I refuse to sell out.

ELLA
I'm just saying. Why should people work with you if they don't know you?

SCOTT
That can wait for until after I get to know you.

Scott and Ella are inching closer together.

ELLA
Barely.

The tension is so thick you can feel it. They forgot about Dom and the party and are now only looking at each other.

SCOTT

Then let's go on a date.

ELLA

Glad you're one of the guys who asks straight away. There were other guys talking me up who couldn't get their intentions out.

SCOTT

So had we met any minute late, I might have missed out?

ELLA

I'm not saying I'm that easy. My bar's just higher than "what's your favorite movie?" followed by them talking about their favorites.

SCOTT

Yikes, who does that?

Dom's having a good time. He's in a different circle now, still talking. They laugh together. The girl next to him places her hand on his thigh while trying to look him in the eyes.

ELLA (O.S.)

You'd be surprised.

INT. ELLA'S APARTMENT - DAY

Ella's room in a shared apartment near USC. It's neat and organized. Posters of various bands, from Radiohead to Hitsujibungaku decorate her walls.

Ella is sitting on her bed in dolphin shorts and an oversized t-shirt, tuning her guitar. She's going by ear, focused on finding the right note.

Ella plugs some cables from her audio interface around to connect it to her laptop. She puts her headphones on-ready to record.

Next to the laptop are notes with verses written on them. Some words are legible.

Please look at me.

Stare down until you see-

Ella grips the fingerboard. Before she can play, a loud vibration cuts the moment short. Her phone's alarm.

Hesitating-she had just found the right note-Ella folds her laptop, shoves it into a backpack and heads out.

INT. LECTURE HALL - LATER

University of Southern California.

Scott is sitting in a screenwriting lecture, paying attention to the man at the board with the rest of class.

Dom's sitting front row, straight as a candle.

Herbert GREENBLATT, 50s, is scanning the incoming students who are waiting for him to teach them all there is to know.

GREENBLATT

First of all, welcome to SCA. The lucky three percent right here. Waiting for me to show them how to write a movie. You didn't spend that tuition on nothing, right? Don't worry, you'll learn the ins and outs soon enough. If not here, then in another course. Definitely once you land a gig. But that might not come for a while. Or ever. Now, first comes learning. Creating. You're all here to write a script. What you need to figure out is what you want to write about for this course. What will your script be about? Come up with two to four sentences by the end of today's lecture.

Dom is already at it, writing down a couple of ideas. Crossing some out immediately.

Horror comedy? ~~Interstellar meets Rashomon~~. A model murders her agent.

GREENBLATT (cont'd)

Also, don't expect your first draft to be right. Not even your second draft will be anywhere near good. Most people take this class at least four times. Had one who took it eleven times. No idea where that guy's at today.

Most students laugh.

GREENBLATT (cont'd)
Now, who of you already thought up a
movie? I want to see hands for
everyone who has at least a logline.

Most hands shoot up, including Dom. Scott doesn't move, he
doesn't have any idea. He sink into his chair.

GREENBLATT (cont'd)
Okay, now who of you is ready to
share that idea right now?

About half of those who raised their hands, including Dom,
lower their hands.

GREENBLATT (cont'd)
Now, of those with their hands still
up high, who has written the script
from their logline? Finished scripts.

Two people still have their hands up.

GREENBLATT (cont'd)
Smart move of those who lowered their
hands when I asked who was ready to
share. This is a predatory industry.
Ideas don't come with copyright. Once
you wrote your script, you own the
intellectual property on your story.
So for those who still had their
hands up, get to writing. And those
who haven't even thought up a simple
log line: Don't worry. That's what
this course is for.

Greenblatt smiles as he delivers that last line. Perhaps he
looked at Scott there, perhaps not. Scott certainly felt
like that was for him alone.

Dom looks like he wants to pat himself on the back, as if he
knew what Greenblatt was playing at.

GREENBLATT (cont'd)
This is the most important lesson,
hence why I say it so soon. Always be
ready for an elevator pitch. But make
sure that's the right person in there
with you.

INT. BAR - NIGHT

A group of beautiful college girls. We can't hear them.

HEATH (O.S.)
 (in DiCaprio's Jordan
 Belfort voice)
 Oh, I swear. I can't believe how
 beautiful you are. What's your name?
 God, even your name? Do you ever stop
 being perfect?

Scott is out drinking with his friends and acting students
 HEATH and RYAN. There's a small bowl of olives between them.

Heath is practicing a show for them, akin to drunk method
 acting. He's got the role down, just lacking common sense.

HEATH
 Me? Heath, acting freshman at USC.
 Now listen, I'm not trying to sell
 you a pen or anything. Quite the
 opposite, I want to buy you
 something. A drink. And we can talk
 all about how you want to make it
 big, I want to make it big, this town
 is amazing, this town is awful. Who
 cares. A small drink in exchange for
 a good time with me. Say, darling, do
 we have a deal?

A stunned beat. Scott and Ryan aren't sure if their friend
 is insanely talented or insane and talented.

Heath is waiting for their reaction.

SCOTT	RYAN
It's...	Uh...

HEATH
 You think that will work on the girl
 over there?

RYAN
 Do you have to act like the Wolf of
 Wall Street for this? Why not, dunno,
 James Bond?

HEATH
 I'm not good with accents yet.

RYAN
 (to Scott)
 Back to that professor.

SCOTT

Prof's sending lots of mixed signals.
He asked about who had any ideas
already, and my mind just went blank.

HEATH

Dude, those film guys just want to be
impressed. You can do that. Speaking
of, I've got to hone my skills and
impress that pretty girl over there.

SCOTT

Which one's your target, anyway?

Back to the girls. One of them is eating the peanuts at the
center of their booth. Then, for a microsecond, she looks
over to the guys.

HEATH (O.S.)

The one nibbling on the peanuts.

Heath gets up and walks over.

SCOTT

Good luck.

RYAN

I wish he'd act like a normal person
for once. I don't put on any acts
when I go out.

SCOTT

And he interrupts us for those
things. Annoying sometimes.

RYAN

Right, back to that. I don't get why
you're afraid. You're the most
creative guy I know. Always coming up
with stories.

SCOTT

But now there's competition. It's not
like you and Heath, who get to act
together. Writing is a lonely craft.

RYAN

I think you're wrong on both parts.
Plenty of writer duos out there.
Students tend to form circles, too.

SCOTT

That's the thing. On one hand, you
need the connections.

(MORE)

SCOTT (cont'd)
On the other hand, you just need the
connections to serve yourself.

RYAN
That's how I feel about acting. I'm
not talking about on stage, I mean
what comes before. Landing gigs.

SCOTT
That's not how you feel about Heath,
though, right?

RYAN
You two are my best friends. No doubt
about that.

SCOTT
You're making me blush.

RYAN
But if I ever went head to head for a
lead role with Heath-

The sound of a fat slap. Scott and Ryan look over to Heath.
He's holding his cheek. The girl he talked up is staring
daggers. The other girls are backing her up.

Ryan looks back to Scott as he pierces an olive with his
toothpick.

RYAN (cont'd)
...I'd throw him under the bus.

Scott is giving his friend a dirty look. Some part of him
refuses to believe that his friend could be such a
backstabber.

Meanwhile Heath makes his return, holding his cheek. Scott
and Ryan are waiting for an explanation as Heath slides back
onto the bench.

HEATH
I don't think she's seen the movie.